IDENTIFYING A MAGIC ITEM (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Some magic items look **ordinary**, others are **obviously magical**. Either way, touching an item **does not reveal its properties**. This sheet explains how to learn them, and why a **curse** changes things.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. The **Identify** spell is the fastest way to reveal an item's properties.
2. Without the spell: a **Short Rest** spent in physical contact with the item, focused on it. At the end, you learn its properties and how to use them, but **not its curse**.
3. A **potion**: a small taste is enough to know what it does.
4. **Clues** (etched command words, design motifs) can hint at its purpose.
5. For other items, you **try them out**: the DM describes what the character notices.

⚠ Cursed item:

- The Short Rest **does not reveal** the curse.
- Attunement can't be ended **voluntarily** with a cursed item.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The text gives **no check** to examine an item, and doesn't say how to suspect a curse. Fix: a table method using the Study action (How to play page), announced before the game.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the item through sensations: a tingle in the fingers, a strange weight, a rune that flares for a moment, a chill that doesn't come from the room.

Step 1 – Observe the item:

The DM describes what can be seen: etched command words, motifs, materials. These **clues** can hint at its purpose, without proving it.

Step 2 – Choose the method:

Method	What you learn
Identify spell	Properties, how to use it, attunement needed, charges. See the spell at the end of this sheet.
Short Rest in contact with the item	Properties and use, but not the curse.
Taste a potion	What the potion does.
Try out the item	What the DM describes: at your own risk.

Step 3 – Study the item: Table rule

Study action: an **Intelligence** (**Arcana**) check. The DM sets the DC by the item's rarity, announced before the roll.

Rarity	DC
Common	10
Uncommon	15
Rare	20
Very Rare	25
Legendary	30

Success: a clue about the item's use (not all its properties). **Failure**: nothing useful.

Example: Lysa (Arcana +5) studies an uncommon dagger (DC 15). She rolls 11 + 5 = 16: success, she works out that the blade lights up near the undead.

Step 4 – Attune to the item:

- **Attunement** takes a Short Rest focused on that item alone, in physical contact. If the rest is interrupted, attunement fails.
- You can be attuned to no more than **three magic items** at a time.
- Attunement ends if you no longer meet the prerequisites, or if the item is more than **100 feet** away for at least 24 hours.
- You can end it voluntarily with another Short Rest, **unless the item is cursed**.

Common table questions.

Do I need the Identify spell?

No: it is the fastest way, but a Short Rest in contact with the item is enough for its properties.

Does the Short Rest reveal a curse?

No: you learn the properties and how to use them, not the curse.

Can I taste a potion?

Yes: a small taste is enough to know what it does.

How many attuned items can I have?

No more than three magic items at a time.

Can I break attunement to a cursed item?

Not voluntarily with a Short Rest. Some spells can break the bond: see their description.

Is Detect Magic enough?

No: it reveals the presence of a magical effect and, if it comes from a spell, its school, but not properties. See the **Detect Magic** sheet.

Can I use an item without identifying it?

Yes, by trying it out: the DM describes what the character notices. Be careful with a suspect item.

Table rule

How do I suspect a curse?

The text doesn't say. Table option: the DM signals a "bad feeling" about a clue (etched word, dark aura) without revealing its nature.

Table rule

What about identifying a spell?

See the **Identifying a Spell** sheet.

The Identify spell:

Level 1 Divination (Bard, Wizard). Casting Time: 1 minute or Ritual. Range: Touch. Components: V, S, M (a pearl worth 100+ GP). Duration: Instantaneous. You touch an object during the casting: if it is magical, you learn its properties and how to use it, whether it requires attunement, and how many charges it has. You learn whether any ongoing spells are affecting it, and what they are.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Telling if an effect is magical

The game text says whether an effect is magical. Effects from spells and magic items always are.

Permanent effects

A permanent magical effect can be dispelled, unless its description says otherwise.

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